

THE SYSTEM AGAINST THE INDIVIDUAL

An overall reading of the contradictions of the contemporary world

In brief

- The system produces a great deal, but does not turn that wealth proportionately into security, time and capacity for choice for people.
- The individual is asked to take responsibility for results that depend on conditions they do not control.
- Those who decide, those who benefit and those who pay are more and more often different people.
- The present is financed by transferring costs onto the future.
- This is why correcting the effects is not enough: the conditions that produce them must be changed.

The contemporary world can be described through data on growth, productivity, debt, poverty, resources and climate. But a person does not experience GDP: a person experiences the possibility of working, having a home, receiving care, studying, having relationships, having time and imagining a future. The central question therefore becomes the relationship between what the system produces and what it concretely allows people to live. The problem of the present is not necessarily that the system produces too little. It could be, on the contrary, that it produces enormously without proportionately transforming this wealth into security, freedom, time and capacity to choose.

From the individual's point of view, the economy is a concrete chain: time, work, income, home, consumption, savings, health, relationships, security, future. It is through this chain that the great phenomena are perceived: growth becomes the cost of housing, monetary policy the cost of credit, demographic transformation caring for one's parents or the difficulty of having children, climate change the cost of food. This is why a society can be richer overall and leave many individuals with a growing difficulty in building autonomy.

Modern capitalism has built part of its legitimacy around an implicit promise: those who work, educate themselves, save and take on responsibility should be able to improve their condition progressively. The individual is asked to get an education, keep up to date, be competitive, save and be flexible. But the individual does not

determine housing prices, interest rates, the labour market or the cost of energy. The consequences are individualised while many of the causes are systemic. It is the first contradiction: one can be responsible for one's own choices without really being master of the conditions within which those choices produce their effects. This does not eliminate personal responsibility. It does, however, impose a condition of justice: responsibility should be proportionate to the effective capacity to influence the causes.

Productivity can increase enormously without its benefit being automatically transformed into greater security or freedom. The same increase can become wages, profit, investment, lower prices, public service, shorter working hours or greater accumulation: there is no automatic distribution of technological progress. And when a growing share of the value produced separates from the income distributed to labour, demand has to be sustained by other means, from public spending to credit, which may also simply shift the problem forward in time. The question is not whether technology is good or bad. It is who controls the benefit it produces and in what form that benefit returns to society.

The home makes the contradiction evident. It is at once a fundamental need, an asset, an investment and financial collateral: for those who own capital it can represent security and wealth, for those who lack it, it can become a barrier to entry into stability. Inequality, in fact, does not concern only the quantity of goods owned. Wealth allows one to wait, take risks, withstand crises, protect oneself and choose. The difference is not only how much you own. It is how much you can afford to decide, and how far you can modify the conditions within which others, too, have to live.

Democracy formally grants citizens a political voice; the market, by contrast, distributes economic capacity according to property, income and capital. The two logics come into tension when an economic decision produces an immediate benefit for some and costs distributed over others: a firm gains efficiency while a territory faces changes in employment, an investment produces a return while others bear environmental costs. The decisive problem then emerges: who decides, who benefits, who pays and who can correct the decision? When these four positions grow too far apart, economic inequality also becomes a question of legitimacy. This is perhaps the deepest form of systemic injustice: living inside decisions that one did not help to make and that one does not have the capacity to correct.

Millions of rational decisions can produce a result that no one chose. A person may decide to have fewer children because the cost of living is too high: it is an understandable choice. But if many people make the same choice, the population ages, the pressure on care and pension systems increases, and the next generation

may find itself in even more difficult conditions. A system can transform individual rationality into collective irrationality. The problem is not only to correct people's behaviour: it is to build institutions capable of coordinating individual interests towards collectively sustainable results.

The present can be financed by transferring costs onto the future. Debt makes it possible to bring forward future economic capacity: it is not negative in itself, but it becomes problematic when a growing share of future income has to be used to sustain obligations already created. The same happens outside finance. An economy also uses natural resources, health, time, infrastructure, trust, human capital and social capital: if it consumes them faster than it manages to replenish them, it can increase production in the short term while reducing its own future capacity. The fundamental question changes: not how much we can produce, but how much we can produce without consuming the conditions of future production.

A system can be unequal, inefficient and even produce crises without immediately losing legitimacy. The fracture grows deeper when the conviction spreads that the ordinary instruments are no longer sufficient to correct it. If the individual thinks "I can study, work, save and behave responsibly, but the fundamental conditions of my life are decided elsewhere", the question is no longer only economic. It becomes institutional.

If these contradictions were only occasional errors, it would be sufficient to correct them. But if they derive from the very way in which property, labour, production and power are organised, redistribution alone cannot be the definitive answer. Redistribution acts on the result; systemic change must act on the conditions that produce it. It means production that starts from real need and not from price, necessary labour that becomes contribution, fundamental goods held in common custody, a market that remains an instrument, power that is a temporary function and not a position, technology that helps to decide but does not decide, progress measured by sufficiency. And it starts from the individual: no one must be deprived of necessary goods because they do not own enough.

The conclusion to which this analysis leads is that capitalism must no longer be the dominant principle of social organisation. Not simply because it is considered morally unsatisfactory, but because it is no longer capable of reconciling production, freedom, justice, sustainability and responsibility. Capitalism must end. But this sentence acquires meaning only if one understands what comes after: if the fundamental structures remain the same, the problem may simply reappear in another form.

There does not exist today a complete, verified and universally applicable alternative system. This is why the alternative must be built, and it is here that the Constitution of the Circles takes on its meaning: not as a perfect model nor as a dogma, but as the

first concrete architecture of an alternative that does not yet fully exist. It will have to be tested, it will have to fail at certain points, it will have to be corrected, because the greatest risk would be to replace a system that claims to be inevitable with another that claims to be perfect. We do not yet know what the society to come will be in its definitive form. But we do know which contradictions we can no longer ignore.

The end of capitalism is not the point of arrival. It is the point at which the hardest work begins. We are not obliged to regard the system we have inherited as inevitable. But if we want to go beyond it, we cannot limit ourselves to rejecting it. We must become capable of building another way of living.